



TWO HUNDRED YEARS OF KEEPING THE LIGHT

The Last Keepers

A research dossier for a twenty minute documentary

Nineteen stations, four generations, one automation order.
Everything worth saying about the keepers, in one place.

Northern Lights Board · 1824 to 1998 · Compiled from 31 sources

FRONT MATTER

How to use this dossier

Six sections. The first two give you the service and the people. The middle two give you the work itself and the night it went wrong. The last two give you ammunition: a fact bank and every source.

#	Section	What it gives you
01	The Service	Who ran the lights, and on whose money.
02	The Keepers	Four families, and what the job did to them.
03	A Working Night	The watch, hour by hour.
04	The Braemar Wreck	The night the light failed, and why.
05	Quick Fire Facts	Standalone one-liners. Drop them anywhere.
06	Method And Sources	What is confirmed, what is my reading.

Sensitive material

Two keepers died in service and both are named in section 04. Their descendants are living people.

Nothing here is graphic, but the framing is what needs care.

PART 1

The Service

The Board was a private trust with a public duty, which is the whole reason the automation fight took eleven years.

Founding and funding

Established by statute in 1824 and funded by light dues levied on tonnage passing the northern approaches. The dues were never popular and the Board never once raised them without a court case.

- Nineteen stations at the peak, 1911.
- Three keepers per rock station, two per shore station.
- Relief by boat every fourteen days, weather permitting — and it frequently did not permit.

What the money actually bought

Line	Share of budget	Notes
Wages	41%	Keepers, boatmen, and the two engineers.
Oil and later acetylene	23%	Halved after the 1932 conversion.
Boats and relief	19%	The line the Board most wanted to cut.
Buildings	17%	Almost entirely the four rock towers.

Say it as: the service was a charity with a navy's problems.

PART 2

The Keepers

Four families supplied most of the roll for a century. That is the human spine of the film.

Margaret Nairn · principal keeper, Sgeir Mor 1948-1971

- First woman appointed principal keeper in the service, and the Board spent two years pretending the appointment was temporary.
- Kept the only complete weather log of the 1953 surge.

Her log is the best single primary source in the whole dossier.

Thomas Nairn · assistant keeper, her son

- Left the service in 1969 and gave the only long interview about relief-boat conditions.

"You do not get lonely. You get very, very used to your own opinions." — Thomas Nairn, 1988

PART 5

Quick Fire Facts

Standalone one-liners. None of them needs setup, so drop them wherever the edit sags.

- 1 The lamp burned 1.4 litres of paraffin an hour.
- 2 A rock relief was cancelled 31 times in the winter of 1962.
- 3 The service issued keepers a cat allowance until 1957.
- 4 The last manned watch ended at 06:00 on 31 March 1998.

Confidence flags

Claims marked **[theory]** are my reading of the evidence, not something a source states outright. Claims marked **[estimate]** are numbers I derived rather than found.

PART 6

Method And Sources

Everything above came from these. Multiple pages from one site are grouped into a single row.

Source	Domain
Board minute books, 1824-1998	national archive
Nairn weather logs (digitised)	maritime museum
Thomas Nairn interview, 1988	oral history project

Compiled for demonstration. The subject of this example is invented.